

Act One: From Cell to Sand

A Homebrew D&D 5e Adventure Module & DM Campaign Guide (Refined Edition)

FEATURING ENHANCED MECHANICS, SPOTLIGHT PACING & INTERACTIVE BOSS SEALS

Welcome to the revised and expanded edition of **Act One: From Cell to Sand**. This document is engineered to guide Dungeon Masters through an unforgettable campaign opener. It combines intense sensory immersion, dynamic player agency, and interactive environmental mechanics to introduce an overarching cosmological threat: the return of the Demon Prince Solomon Grundy and his rivalry with the Goddess of Magic, Mystra.

Scene 1: Setting the Stage (The Awakening)

The campaign begins not in a lively tavern, but in the oppressive darkness of a subterranean gladiator cell. Before asking for standard perception rolls, use tailored sensory descriptions to validate your players' class choices immediately upon waking.

READ-ALoud TO THE TABLE

Imagine the light in this room dimming, flickering, casting long, dancing shadows around you. Can you hear it? A low, ominous hum, perhaps the distant clatter of chains, and a muffled roar, like a crowd far, far away. This is the sound of your new reality.

As consciousness slowly returns, a wave of pain and disorientation washes over you. What is the very first thing you feel, smell, or hear?

Pause for each player's response. Then, based on their class and background, deliver a personalized physical sensation:

- **To the Mage / Arcane Caster:** You taste the acrid tang of burnt spell components on your tongue. A throbbing headache pulses behind your eyes, and the phantom sensation of a powerful ward shattering still lingers in your mind like ringing glass.
- **To the Warrior / Barbarian / Brawler:** Your jaw aches, bruised ribs protest with every shallow, dusty breath, and there is the distinct metallic taste of blood in your mouth. Your muscles are stiff, strained from a brutal, forgotten struggle.
- **To the Rogue / Sneak / Ranger:** Rough, freezing stone presses against your cheek. You catch the faint scent of stale sweat and underlying fear, while a subtle thrumming sensation suggests an active magical dampener suppressing your agility and senses.
- **To the Cleric / Paladin / Divine Caster:** A profound spiritual unease settles deep within your chest—a suffocating feeling of your divine connection being muffled by unholy wards, accompanied by a dull ache where your holy symbol used to rest.

FLASHBACK PROMPT (SELECT ONE PLAYER)

A hazy, fragmented flashback sears through your mind: a sudden, overwhelming ambush in the dark, a crushing kinetic force, and then the sickening sensation of being dragged by unseen captors into the depths of the earth. That is all you remember of your arrival.

Open the Floor: Ask all players: "Now that you are somewhat aware, what do you do? Do you assess your immediate surroundings, test your restraints, or call out into the darkness?" Be prepared for them to attempt strength checks on chains, search the walls, or try communicating with adjacent cells.

Scene 2: Who and Where? – The Barren Cell

As players begin exploring their prison, describe the spartan, rough-hewn stone architecture. The cell is cold and stripped of comfort, yet layered with environmental storytelling.

- **Crude Carvings & Occult Runes:** The walls are covered in etched graffiti depicting gladiatorial combat—figures locked in brutal struggle against strange, monstrous beasts. A successful *DC 12 Intelligence (Arcana or Religion)* check reveals that these carvings incorporate archaic binding runes and demonic glyphs, hinting that these games serve an occult ritual purpose rather than mere entertainment.
- **Heavy Iron Chains:** Bolted into the stone are massive iron cuffs. Noticeably well-maintained and polished from frequent friction, a grim realization sets in: these restraints see constant, heavy turnover.
- **Sliver of Window:** High above, a narrow slit offers a glimpse outside. It reveals a perpetual twilight sky painted with unfamiliar, multi-hued astral auroras. One thing is indisputable: you are no longer on your home plane, or at least nowhere within mapped geography.

The Screaming Neighbor

From beyond the heavy cell door, the muffled cheers of a distant stadium surge and recede. Suddenly, a panicked voice from a neighboring cell breaks through the din, sobbing and begging for someone to release them, swearing their innocence.

DM Branching Outcomes:

- **If the party ignores the voice:** The screams fade into ragged whimpers and eventually a dead silence, leaving a heavy, foreboding dread. (This establishes a grim, unforgiving tone).
- **If the party responds or converses:** The voice becomes frantic, pleading for names and offering fragmented rumors about "the masters" and "blood sacrifices for the chained god." Halfway through the sentence, a dull thrum echoes, and the prisoner's voice is cut short by a terrifying, low chuckle from a different, unseen entity further down the hall.

Scene 3: A Risky Opportunity – The Loose Brick

When players thoroughly search the perimeter or succeed on a *DC 12 Wisdom (Perception)* or *Intelligence (Investigation)* check, their fingers catch on a loose mortar line.

With a concerted push, a heavy stone brick grinds out of place, revealing a dark, cramped maintenance tunnel pulling air from somewhere deeper in the complex. It promises potential escape, but carries a high risk of discovery.

DM GUIDANCE: BOUNCING THE SPOTLIGHT (SPLIT-PARTY PACING)

If the party splits—some crawling into the tunnel while others stay behind—you must manage table flow strictly to prevent boredom or frustration. Do not let either group sit idle for more than **3 to 5 minutes** at a time.

- **Run in Beats:** Give the tunnel team one physical obstacle (a tight squeeze requiring a DC 10 Athletics/Acrobatics check or a crumbling ledge), let them roll, and pause their narrative just as they hear voices echoing ahead.
- **Cut to the Cell:** Immediately turn to the remaining prisoners. Have guards approach the cell door, rattle keys, or deliver meager rations, demanding to know where the others went.
- **Sync the Timeline:** Align the culmination of both paths. Whether captured in the cell or intercepted in the armory, both groups should merge seamlessly into the Orientation sequence without feeling like one side missed the adventure.

Branching Paths:

- **If they wait in the cell:** After a tense period, armored gladiatorial handlers arrive to chain the remaining prisoners for the upcoming exhibition, leading directly to the Orientation Walk.
- **If they signal for help through the walls:** They attract the attention of a brutal overseer who bangs his mace against the door, threatening severe punishment if the noise continues. However, a high Persuasion or Deception roll might coax a cryptic warning from a superstitious guard regarding "the glowing stones in the sand."
- **If they enter the tunnel:** The passage is suffocatingly tight, dusty, and lined with sharp stone. Faintly ahead, the clanging of weapons and gruff voices grow louder with every inch they crawl.

Scene 4: The Armory Infiltration (Skill Challenge)

Note: This section replaces the traditional "unwinnable combat trap" with a structured Skill Challenge. Forcing a tactical combat encounter that is rigged for defeat frustrates players and punishes exploration. A Skill Challenge rewards their cleverness while still serving the narrative need to get them to the arena.

As the crawling heroes push aside a loose wooden grate, they emerge behind a stack of heavy crates inside a bustling armory and staging area. Two veteran arena quartermasters are currently busy

sharpening greatswords at a grinding stone, their backs turned. Weapon racks line the walls, and a reinforced door leading toward the arena pens sits thirty feet away.

THE ARMORY INFILTRATION SKILL CHALLENGE

Goal: Secure weapons, armor, potions, or tactical intelligence before being detected and corralled into the arena pens.

Complexity: The party must achieve **3 Successes before 2 Failures**. Allow players to propose creative uses of their skills, but use the following baseline DCs:

- **Stealth (DC 13):** Silently darting between weapon racks to snatch gear without alerting the busy quartermasters.
 - **Sleight of Hand (DC 12):** Lifting a dagger, a key ring, or a glowing vial (Potion of Healing) from a nearby workbench.
 - **Perception / Investigation (DC 12):** Scanning the room to memorize a tactical map of the arena pits or notice structural weaknesses in the incoming guards' armor.
 - **Deception / Performance (DC 14):** If a quartermaster turns around, a player can mimic an overseer's voice or create a timed diversion to buy seconds for an ally.
 - **Arcana / Religion (DC 13):** Identifying that the weapons being sharpened are coated in a specialized oil designed to conduct magical energy.
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Challenge Outcomes:

- **Total Success (3 Successes):** The infiltration is a tactical triumph! Each participating player may begin Scene 5 with a **simple weapon of their choice, a shield, or a Potion of Healing**. Just as they secure their loot, a heavy iron portcullis drops, and a dozen elite guards enter with leveled crossbows. Outnumbered and with nowhere to run, the party is forced to surrender and march to the pits—but they earned a vital mechanical edge for the boss fight!
- **Total Failure (2 Failures):** A player knocks over a spear rack or steps on a creaky floorboard. A quartermaster instantly blows a shrill alarm whistle. Within seconds, a dozen elite guards flood the room with halberds raised. Realizing they are vastly overpowered, the party is disarmed and roughly subdued without a tedious combat slog, then dragged directly into the orientation halls.

The Orientation Walk

Regardless of how they are captured, the party is marched together through the grand, vaulted corridors of the colosseum complex. They catch terrifying glimpses of what awaits: holding pens filled with snarling, exotic beasts, gladiators chanting dark prayers, and high above through ornate arches, opulent spectator balconies where shadowy patricians and robed figures observe with calculating coldness.

Scene 5: Trial by Fire – The Runes of Binding

The party is thrust through massive bronze gates into blinding, midday sunlight. The roar of the crowd is a deafening, visceral wave of sound that shakes their chests. The air is thick with dry dust, ozone, and the undeniable stench of blood. You are in the arena.

Facing you across the sandy pit are two veteran gladiators wielding mismatched, brutal weaponry—one swinging a spiked net and a trident, the other brandishing a notched greatsword. However, the true focal point of the battlefield lies beneath your feet.

DM GUIDANCE: THE INTERACTIVE SEAL MECHANICS

To ensure the narrative twist hits with emotional weight, the players must physically cause Solomon Grundy's release during this fight. The arena floor is actually the physical anchor of his ancient divine prison. The enemy gladiators—secretly cultists of Grundy—will fight with tactics designed to trick the heroes into shattering the seal.

ARENA HAZARD: THE FOUR CELESTIAL RUNESTONES

Embedded in the sand are **four massive, glowing runestones** pulsing with pale, divine blue light. Spectral chains of magic stream from these stones into a dark, barred iron gate sealed into the center of the arena floor. The stones have **AC 12 and 15 HP**, but they interact dynamically with combat:

- Arcane Absorption:** The runestones are designed to absorb and siphon magical energy to reinforce the prison. Whenever a player or creature casts a spell of 1st level or higher within 10 feet of a runestone, the stone flares violently with violet light and cracks, absorbing the spell's kinetic energy to weaken the seal.
- Blood on the Glyphs:** The gladiators will actively attempt to grapple, shove, or lure players directly onto the glowing runestones. If any creature takes piercing or slashing damage while standing on a stone, their blood seeps into the carvings, causing the rune to shatter with the sound of breaking glass.
- Tactical Destruction:** A player might mistake the runestones for enemy buff generators and intentionally attack them. When a runestone is attacked and destroyed, the crowd cheers wildly as the central iron gate shudders and groans.

Tracking the Seal: Keep a tally behind your screen. Once **three of the four runestones** are shattered, blood-soaked, or overloaded by spellcraft, the final gladiator falls, the arena violently quakes, and the Cliffhanger sequence triggers immediately.

Cliffhanger Ending & The Twist: Goddess and Betrayal

You strike down the final gladiator. Exhausted, bleeding, but exhilarated, you stand victorious upon the sand. But there is no celebration. The bloodthirsty cheers of the massive crowd abruptly die down, replaced by an eerie, suffocating silence.

An ominous, deep horn blast echoes through the stadium, resonant enough to vibrate the teeth in your skulls. In the center of the arena, the heavy barred gate—now stripped of its spectral chains—begins to grind open, revealing a bottomless void of darkness.

READ-ALoud: THE DIVINE MANIFESTATION

Before whatever lurks within can emerge, a blinding flash of pure, divine light erupts from the heavens, momentarily eclipsing the sun. A figure of immense, timeless majesty manifests suspended in the air—Mystra, the Goddess of Magic and Mother of Mysteries. Her eyes burn with righteous wrath, yet her posture carries the profound weariness of ancient struggles.

But as her light washes over the sand, a guttural, booming roar tears through the arena. From the central pit bursts Solomon Grundy. He appears monstrous and towering, but visibly strained, fighting against lingering unseen forces as spectral, burning chains dissolve around his wrists.

Mystra: *(Voice echoing with divine authority, cutting through the stadium)* "Solomon Grundy! You will return to the abyss from which you came. Your corruption ends here upon the sand!"

Solomon Grundy: *(A low, rumbling laugh that shakes the stone arches, a sneer playing on his pale lips)* "Mystra... lightbringer, chainsmith, goddess of forgotten prisons... your titles grow ever more tiresome. Are you certain you weren't the goddess of tedium? Always so predictable... always so late."

Mystra: "Silence your venomous tongue! Your realm is sealed, and your time of influence has expired!"

Solomon Grundy: *(Feigning wound, placing a massive hand over his chest)* "Such cruelty! And after my unwitting champions so kindly undid your masterpiece?" *(He turns his glowing, predatory gaze directly toward the players, gesturing at the shattered runestones).* "Look at them! Every spell they cast near your wards, every drop of blood they spilled upon your glyphs, every desperate strike to survive—it shattered your seals! I didn't break my chains, Mystra. **They broke them for me.**"

Mystra: *(Looking toward the party with urgent sorrow)* "Do not let his venom twist your hearts! You were deceived by shadows, yes, but there is still time to choose your path—to right this grievous wrong!"

Solomon Grundy: *(Cutting her off with a dismissive wave of his hand as dark energy erupts around him)* "Ah, the appeal to righteousness! Did your teachings not cover the concept of unintended consequences, little goddess? I thank my unwitting champions for their exceptional dedication. But a weary demon prince has kingdoms to claim... and favors to collect from my new acquaintances."

Before Mystra can unleash her divine wrath, Grundy acts. With a mocking bow toward the party that is both an insult and a promise, he sinks into the arena floor. He dissolves into a swirling swarm of shadowy, demonic locusts that disperse into the cracks of the stone, leaving behind only the choking scent of brimstone and a scorched outline on the sand.

Aftermath & Campaign Impact (Moving to Act Two)

The arena is in chaos. Mystra slowly descends to the sand, her form flickering slightly—a testament to the strain of maintaining cosmic boundaries. She fixes her gaze upon the party with a complex mixture of sorrow, empathy, and absolute determination. The weight of correcting this cosmic mistake now falls upon your shoulders.

Key DM Considerations for Act Two:

- **The Goddess's Mark:** How will Mystra mark the party for this quest?
 - *The Divine Tracker:* A glowing, silver rune branded onto their forearms that warms or pulses whenever Grundy's demonic influence or cultists are near.

- *The Lingering Echo*: A faint, unsettling curse left by Grundy's exposure—perhaps causing minor physical unease in holy sites, acting as a constant reminder of their mistake.
- *The Ambiguous Blessing*: A surge of raw divine energy that grants each player a bonus feat or cantrip, but subtly binds their fate to Mystra's divine will, raising moral questions about free will vs. divine servitude.
- **Lingering Clues on the Sand**: What did Grundy leave behind in his hasty exit?
 - Scorched abyssal symbols burned into the sand that point toward a specific geographic coordinate or ruined city.
 - A discarded shard of his shattered divine seal—an artifact radiating ancient magic that can be studied by scholars or used to craft a weapon capable of harming him.
 - A corrupted gladiator weapon dripping with shadow ichor that whispers secrets to whoever wields it.
- **Hunted or Aided?**: How does the world react to the seal's destruction?
 - *The Hunters*: The arena masters, zealous paladins of rival deities, or surviving cultists who want to tie up loose ends begin hunting the party across the wilderness.
 - *The Allies*: Remnants of Mystra's forgotten order or shady mercenaries who also seek Grundy's downfall emerge from the shadows to offer shelter and information.

Brainstorming the Act Two Setting

Where does the party transition once they escape the colosseum?

1. The Devastated Arena Complex

The party remains in the ruined colosseum, sneaking through underground vaults, fighting surviving beasts, and interrogating captured overseers while avoiding Mystra's celestial guardians.

3. The Desolate Wilderness

They escape into an expansive, corrupted wasteland where Grundy's returning presence is actively twisting the flora and fauna, turning the campaign into an open-world tracking adventure.

2. A Ruined City Outside

They emerge into an ancient, crumbling metropolis adjacent to the arena—a place ravaged by Grundy's historical fall, offering urban exploration, survivor factions, and hidden cult archives.

4. The Shadow Realm Incursion

They are accidentally pulled through the tear in the veil left by Grundy's departure, forcing them to navigate a minor demonic plane to find a way back to the Material Plane.

| Grundy's First Temptation (Personal Nighttime Scene)

This encounter is designed for a single player—ideally the character who took the most damage during the arena fight, or one whose backstory revolves around a quest for power or deep regret. Run this scene during the party's first long rest after escaping the arena.

You have made a makeshift camp in a secluded alcove. The flickering firelight casts long, dancing shadows against the stone, and a heavy exhaustion hangs over the group. Your fitful sleep is plagued

by throbbing pain from your injuries and whispers of doubt. You open your eyes to find yourself alone, your companions frozen in unnatural slumber.

READ-ALoud: THE MIDNIGHT VISITOR

Silhouetted against the dying fire stands a tall, imposing figure. He is impeccably dressed in dark, tailored garments—a stark contrast to the monstrous behemoth you saw in the arena. His unnaturally sharp features are illuminated by the embers, and his smile is smooth, composed, and almost friendly—like a wolf in sheep's clothing.

His voice is a low, hypnotic rumble: "Such a tragic waste... all this raw potential, bleeding out into the dirt."

He steps closer, his boots making no sound. *"Tell me, little hero, does it frustrate you? The fragile weakness of your mortal flesh? The way your companions rely upon your strength, yet you lack the power to truly shield them from a world designed to crush them?"*

Roleplay Branching & Grundy's Responses:

- **If the player is wary or draws a weapon:** He chuckles softly, feigning polite surrender. *"Ah, good. Fear is an exceptional survival instinct. I am merely a curious observer, drawn by the scent of untapped ambition."*
- **If the player is curious or asks what he wants:** His eyes gleam with genuine amusement as he leans in. *"Intriguing. Perhaps there is iron beneath that bruised skin after all. Such spirit can be shaped... honed into something truly immortal."*
- **If the player is defiant or threatens him:** His composure drops for a fraction of a second, his shadow looming predaciously across the camp. *"Brave words for a broken creature. But bravery shatters like brittle bone when faced with true cosmic power."*
- **If the player expresses despair or helplessness:** His tone becomes remarkably sympathetic and gentle. *"I see your pain, child. A crushing burden, carrying the lives of others on shoulders so easily broken."*

DM GUIDANCE: THE IMPLIED BARGAIN

Grundy will not offer an overt, contract-based Warlock pact yet. Instead, he demonstrates his utility. As he speaks, have him gesture casually toward the player; a surge of cool shadow magic washes over them, instantly mending a physical wound or restoring a spent spell slot.

Solomon Grundy: *"Power always demands a price. Always. But some prices are far more palatable than watching those you care for bleed. Imagine the strength to never again feel helpless... to command the very shadows that now hunt you."*

Whether the player is intrigued, horrified, or stoic, Grundy begins to fade into the campfire smoke, leaving behind a final, lingering promise:

Solomon Grundy: *"Sleep on it, little hero. Power has an inevitable way of finding those who crave it. When the day comes that your mortal strength fails you... speak my name in the quiet of your mind. I will be listening."*

Deepening the Lore: The Seal & The Prince

The Nature of the Broken Seal

As players investigate the history of their prison, reveal that the colosseum was not built by mortal kings, but constructed over an ancient divine vault. Why did the seal fail now?

- **The Inexorable March of Time:** Even divine weaves decay over millennia. Mystra's attention was drawn to cosmic wars elsewhere, leaving the wards brittle and susceptible to localized blood rituals.
- **The Tripartite Pact:** The prison originally required three anchors: Divine Law (Mystra), Elemental Earth (an ancient Primordial), and Mortal Will. When the arena masters began using the site for corrupt, blood-sport gambling, the anchor of Mortal Will inverted, rotting the prison from the inside out.

Grundy as a Demon Prince

Ensure players understand that Solomon Grundy is far more dangerous than a mindless fiend. As a Demon Prince, he rules over realms of corruption, ambition, and patient manipulation.

- **Strategic Mastermind:** His true weapon is not his physical strength, but his ability to orchestrate long-term deception. He spent centuries subtly influencing the arena masters in their dreams, designing the tournament rules so that every clash of swords chipped away at his magical bindings.
 - **The Architect of Desires:** Unlike minor demons who trade in simple soul destruction, Grundy trades in justified ambition. He targets heroes, reformists, and protectors, offering them the exact power they need to accomplish noble goals—knowing that the methodology will inevitably corrupt their souls and align them with his abyssal dominion.
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Appendix: Table Management & PVP Contingency Plans

Because this campaign introduces themes of demonic temptation, moral divergence, and internal conflict, it is essential to establish clear table boundaries regarding Player-versus-Player (PVP) interactions.

1. Establish Clear Expectations (Session Zero)

- **The Hard No:** If any player expresses discomfort with interpersonal conflict, establish an absolute table rule: direct, unprovoked hostile actions against fellow PCs are strictly off-limits.
- **Conditional Consent:** If the table is open to dramatic conflict, define the boundaries (e.g., magical mind control, consensual dramatic brawls, or non-lethal subdual).

2. Narrative & Mechanical Approaches to Conflict

- **Demonic Corruption:** If a character accepts Grundy's dark bargains, they might receive secret DM prompts or moral dilemmas that clash with the party's paladin or cleric, driving intense roleplay without resorting to initiative rolls.
- **Non-Lethal Combat Rules:** Encourage players to declare non-lethal strikes. Remind them of 5e rules where melee attacks can reduce a target to 0 HP and leave them unconscious and stable rather than dying.
- **NPC & Environmental Intervention:** If an argument between players threatens to derail the session, use external pacing tools. Have an agent of Mystra cast a non-damaging **Calm Emotions** or **Hold Person** spell, or trigger an immediate environmental hazard (a collapsing wall or monster ambush) that forces the party to unite against a common threat.
- **The "Fade to Black":** If PVP becomes toxic or emotionally uncomfortable at the table, step out of character immediately. Pause the narrative, mediate the conflict as friends, and "fade to black," skipping ahead to a point where the characters have reached a tense truce.